Vaira Salt: Making Salt from an Unused Lagoon

Business Proposal

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Why the lagoon

Jaffna's lagoons are shallow and stay hot most of the year, which is exactly what solar salt production needs. Right now this water is only used for fishing. Sri Lanka still imports a lot of its salt, and the salt sold locally is loose, unbranded, and has no proof of quality. I want to start Vaira Salt to fix that: a small solar saltern that collects lagoon water, dries it into salt, and sells it under one clean brand.

How it works

Lagoon water is moved into shallow ponds. It sits in the sun for a few weeks and turns into salt crystals. Workers rake it up, wash it, dry it, sort it by size, and pack it into food-safe bags. There will be three types: coarse salt for pickling, table salt for cooking, and a fine salt for bath products. Building the ponds costs the most at the start; after that, the main costs are labour and packaging, since the sun does most of the work.

Who will buy it

Households and small shops that now buy imported table salt, if the local option costs the same and looks properly packaged. Food businesses, like pickle makers and dried fish sellers, who need bulk salt they can rely on. Hotels and spas, who want local bath salt as something special for guests.

The monopoly angle

Vaira Salt will not control all salt sales in Sri Lanka. Big coastal salt farms and imported salt are still there, so people can always buy elsewhere. But there is a smaller market this business can control: *branded, food-safe salt made from Jaffna's own lagoons*. Only a few lagoon spots have the right depth and sun for this. If Vaira Salt is first to lease the best spots and build ponds there, a new competitor is stuck choosing a worse spot or trying to take land Vaira Salt already holds. The barrier is not the method, which anyone could copy. It is getting the good land first.

Costs, pricing, and risks

The biggest costs are building and lining the ponds, worker pay, packaging, and food-safety approval. Salt is cheap, so table and coarse salt must be priced close to imported salt; most profit comes from the bath-salt line and bulk contracts. The main risks are weather (a wet season can ruin a harvest), uneven water quality across the lagoon, and the fact that more ponds could harm the lagoon if growth is not managed carefully.

The bigger point

Lagoon salt is not a new idea. What is missing is a business that treats it seriously, with a brand and steady quality, instead of an occasional local harvest. Salt is one of the most ordinary products there is, yet one firm can still become locally dominant here, just by being first to hold the few lagoon sites good enough for the job.